

WRITING SAMPLE

Strengthening the MEL System of a Volunteer-Led Urban Research Association

Phase 1 — MEL System Assessment Report (abridged)

Organisation: Kent Enstitüleri Derneği (Urban Institutes Association), Türkiye

Assignment: Assessment and redesign of the association's monitoring, evaluation and learning system across five city chapters, with particular attention to the cultural heritage protection programme opened after the February 2023 earthquakes

Author's role: Project Manager, Kent Enstitüleri Derneği (2017–2024). The assessment was carried out as an internal assignment after the board identified the gap; the author stepped out of programme management to lead it.

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Note to the reader. This is an abridged extract of an internal deliverable, shared as a writing sample. The annexes covering the stakeholder analysis, the workplan and budget, and the full set of indicator reference sheets have been removed; names of individual staff and partner organisations have been withheld and illustrative figures rounded. The remaining text is substantively as delivered. It is included here because the assignment is a representative example of the work: a small, values-driven organisation with a decentralised structure, an implicit rather than operational theory of change, strong qualitative material that was going unused, and a reporting burden disproportionate to its staffing — with a heritage protection programme that had grown faster than the systems meant to track it.

1. Purpose and scope

Kent Enstitüleri Derneği (KED) is a membership association founded in 2017 to work on urban questions across disciplines — architecture, planning, art history, archaeology, economics, sociology and political science — through public seminar programmes, workshops, field research and publication. It operates through autonomous city chapters, a small coordination function, and a volunteer base drawn largely from academia and the professional chambers.

Following the earthquakes of 6 February 2023, the association opened two new chapters, in Adana and Mersin, and began working directly on the documentation and protection of cultural heritage damaged or threatened in the affected region. Heritage protection is therefore the association's newest and fastest-growing area of work rather than its founding purpose. That distinction matters for what follows: the

assessment concerns KED's monitoring system as a whole, but the strain on that system is concentrated in the programme that has existed for the shortest time.

The board took the decision to commission this assessment in late 2023, in the course of planning for the expansion. Two new chapters, a new field of work and a new class of funder had been added within a year to arrangements that had grown up around a seminar and publication programme, and the board judged — correctly — that those arrangements would not carry the change. I stepped out of my role as Project Manager to lead the work. The assignment was scoped in three phases; this report closes Phase 1.

The assessment was deliberately bounded. It does not evaluate KED's programmes, and it makes no judgement about whether the association is effective. It asks a narrower and more useful question:

Does KED currently generate the evidence it needs in order to make decisions, hold itself accountable to the communities it works with, and report credibly to funders — and if not, what is the smallest system that would?

The word *smallest* carries weight. KED has five paid staff covering coordination and programme delivery across five chapters, and no MEL post. A system that is technically excellent and organisationally unaffordable is a failed system, and the recommendation set in Section 7 is constrained accordingly.

2. Methodology

The assessment was carried out over five weeks in a mixed-methods design. The sequencing was intentional: document review first to establish what the organisation says it does, then interviews to establish what it actually does, then a validation workshop to reconcile the two in the presence of the people who would have to live with the result.

Working from inside the organisation carried an advantage and a risk, and both were managed explicitly. The advantage was access — to informal practice, to the reasoning behind past decisions, and to candour. The risk was that my own prior work as Project Manager was part of what was under assessment. Two safeguards were adopted: the validation workshop was facilitated by a board member rather than by me, and the findings on programme reporting (4.5) were reviewed by a chapter that I had never worked with.

Method	Coverage	Purpose and limitations
Document review	61 documents: constitution, activity reports 2017–2024, 11 grant applications and 9 donor reports, event reports, internal minutes, the 2021 strategy note	Established the de facto results logic and the actual reporting burden. Limitation: the Adana and Mersin chapters were established only in 2023, so the documentary record is necessarily thin for them and the review is weighted toward Ankara, Istanbul and İzmir practice.
Semi-structured interviews	17 interviews: 3 of the 5 paid staff, 4 board members, 6 chapter volunteers (all five chapters), 2 partner neighbourhood initiatives, 2 institutional funders	Surfaced the informal monitoring that documents do not capture. Funder interviews were essential and are often skipped: two of the three reporting requirements staff believed were mandatory turned out not to be.
Data and tools audit	All active spreadsheets, forms, attendance sheets, the shared drive, the mailing list and the archive of field photographs	Quantified duplication and identified data held by individuals rather than the organisation. This produced the single most consequential finding (4.4).
Validation workshop	Half-day, 14 participants across all chapters, held before drafting recommendations	Tested the diagnosis rather than presenting conclusions. Three of the six draft findings were revised as a result; one was dropped.

Two ethical parameters were set at inception and are carried forward into the proposed system. First, no data collection was undertaken with residents or community members during the assessment itself — the association's existing consent basis did not cover it, which is itself a finding (4.6). Second, chapter-level findings were shared with each chapter before being aggregated, on the principle that an assessment which makes volunteers feel audited will produce a system they route around.

3. The current MEL system: what exists

KED does not have "no MEL system." It has an implicit one, built up in layers by different people for different funders, and never consolidated. Naming what already works matters, both analytically and because a redesign that arrives as a verdict on seven years of volunteer labour will not be adopted.

Element	Current state	Maturity	Disposition
Mission and values statement	Clear, widely internalised, quoted verbatim by volunteers in every chapter	Strong	Retain — this is the raw material for the theory of change, not a substitute for it
Theory of change	None documented. A causal logic is reconstructable from grant applications but differs between them	Absent	Develop in Phase 2
Activity records	Every public activity has a date, venue, theme and an approximate headcount, held per chapter	Adequate	Retain, standardise the fields
Event reports	Rich narrative accounts of seminars and workshops, publicly posted; genuinely high quality	Strong but unused	Retain and make analysable — see 6.3
Field documentation of sites	Extensive photography and survey notes, concentrated in the post-2023 earthquake work of the Adana and Mersin chapters; stored across personal drives	Strong content, weak custody	Urgent — see 4.4
Outcome indicators	None. Indicators appear in grant applications and are not tracked afterwards	Absent	Develop in Phase 2
Donor reporting	Reconstructed retrospectively at reporting time from social media, messaging apps and memory	Weak	Replace the process, not the format
Learning practice	Informal, real and effective at chapter level; invisible above it	Informal	Formalise minimally — see 7.2

The pattern is consistent and it is not a capability problem. KED collects a great deal of information and converts almost none of it into a claim it can defend.

KED records a great deal of what it does and can demonstrate very little of what it changes. This is true of the association's work as a whole; it binds hardest on the heritage protection programme opened after 2023, where the practice is newest, the funding most conditional, and the evidence hardest to reconstruct after the fact.

4. Findings

4.1 The theory of change exists, but only in the plural

Eleven grant applications were reviewed. Each contains an implicit causal chain, and they do not agree. Three treat public seminars as the primary mechanism of change (awareness leads to civic pressure leads to protection). Four treat documentation as primary (evidence leads to legal and administrative leverage). Two treat network-building as primary. This is not incoherence for its own sake — it is an organisation writing what each funder wants to hear, which is a rational short-term strategy and a corrosive long-term one.

The practical consequence is that KED cannot prioritise. When the Adana chapter had to choose in 2024 between a seminar series and a rapid documentation response to a demolition, the decision was made on the basis of who was available. That may have been the right call. But it was not a call the organisation was equipped to reason about, because it had no stated view of which pathway carries more of its intended change.

4.2 Monitoring measures attendance because attendance is what a room produces

Across all five chapters, the near-universal metric is the headcount. It is collected because it is available, not because anyone believes it is informative; in interviews, nine of seventeen respondents volunteered, unprompted, that they did not think attendance told them anything. One chapter coordinator put it precisely: "We count the forty people who came. We have no idea about the four who did something afterwards."

This is the classic small-organisation failure mode, and it is worth being exact about why it persists. It is not ignorance of the output-outcome distinction — KED volunteers include academics who teach research methods. It persists because outcome data requires contact with participants after the event, and no one owns that contact. The gap is a process gap, not a knowledge gap, and it should be fixed with a process, not a training.

4.3 The organisation's highest-value work is its least-measured work

KED's advocacy and rapid-response activity — intervening when a structure is scheduled for demolition, submitting objections to conservation boards, producing evidence for professional chambers and courts — is what interviewees across all five chapters named as the work that matters most. It appears in no monitoring instrument whatsoever.

The reason is structural: every existing template is event-shaped. Advocacy is not an event. It is a sequence of contributions to an outcome that other actors also contribute to, unfolding over months, sometimes ending in a decision that would arguably have happened anyway. Standard indicator logic handles this badly, and the honest response is not to force it into an attendance-style count but to change the unit of observation — addressed in 6.2 and Annex A.

4.4 Critical documentation is held by individuals, not by the organisation

The data audit found that the majority of field documentation produced since 2023 — including earthquake-related survey material from the Adana and Mersin chapters that is, in several cases, the only surviving record of structures now demolished — sits on the personal devices and personal cloud accounts of individual volunteers. Two contributors had already left the association. In one instance a folder of approximately 400 photographs of a since-demolished building was recovered during this assessment only because a volunteer happened to still have an old phone.

This is the finding that should be acted on before any framework work begins. It is not, strictly speaking, a MEL finding — but a monitoring system whose underlying evidence base is degrading is being built on sand, and the fix (a custody protocol, a single archive location, and a deposit step attached to activity closure) is cheap, immediate, and independent of everything else in this report. It was implemented in week four rather than being held for Phase 2.

4.5 Reporting is reconstruction, and reconstruction is expensive and unreliable

Because data is not captured as work happens, each donor report is a research project into the organisation's own past. Staff estimated 3–4 person-days per report; the document review supports this. Beyond cost, the quality consequence is that reported figures drift: the same seminar series appears with three different participant totals in three different documents, all produced in good faith.

Interviews with two institutional funders produced a finding staff did not expect. Both said they would accept a shorter, more consistent narrative with fewer figures, provided the figures given were traceable. One had never requested the disaggregation table KED had been producing for three years. Approximately a third of the current reporting burden is self-imposed — a common pattern in small organisations, and the cheapest efficiency available to KED.

4.6 Qualitative material is abundant, valuable and ungoverned

KED holds interview recordings, oral history material and testimony from residents of neighbourhoods facing displacement and from households displaced by the 2023 earthquakes. It is the most compelling evidence the association possesses. It is also collected without a written consent protocol, stored without access controls, and never systematically analysed — it is quarried for quotations when a report needs colour.

Two things follow. Ethically, KED is holding sensitive material about people in precarious housing situations without an adequate basis, and this must be regularised before the material is used more intensively. Methodologically, systematic analysis of what KED already holds would likely answer several outcome questions without a single new data collection instrument — which is the cheapest form of measurement there is.

5. Diagnosis: three underlying causes

The six findings are symptoms of three causes. Treating symptoms individually would produce a longer list of instruments and no improvement.

Cause 1 — The system was built to look upward, so no one internal needs it

Every element of KED's current monitoring exists because a funder asked for it. Nothing exists because a chapter needed it to make a decision. Systems that serve only external accountability are maintained under deadline pressure and decay between deadlines, which is exactly the observed pattern. The design principle for Phase 2 follows directly: every indicator retained must have a named internal decision it feeds. Indicators that serve only reporting are permitted, but must be labelled as such and kept to a minimum, so that the cost of pure compliance is visible rather than diffused.

Cause 2 — Tools were designed for the most complex case, so they are used for none

KED's existing activity report template has 31 fields. It was designed around a large multi-session programme. Applied to a two-hour film screening run by three volunteers, it is absurd, so it is not completed; and because it is not completed for small activities, it is not completed reliably for large ones either. Over-specification does not produce partial data. It produces abandonment.

Cause 3 — The unit of observation does not match the unit of ambition

KED states its ambition in terms of constituencies, public debate, and the standing of heritage and urban rights in formal decision-making. Its instruments record rooms and dates: who attended, where, and when. These are not the same kind of quantity. Counting rooms more carefully produces a better count of rooms; it never accumulates into a defensible statement about standing, because the two sit on different measurement ladders. This is a category mismatch, not a precision problem — and it is the reason volunteers experience

monitoring as bureaucratic. They do not dislike evidence. They dislike collecting evidence of something other than what they are trying to do.

6. Proposed direction for Phase 2

Phase 2 is described in full in the accompanying inception note. Three design decisions are set out here because they were contested in the validation workshop and the reasoning should be on record.

6.1 A two-tier system rather than a uniform one

Cause 2 rules out a single template. The proposed structure is deliberately asymmetric:

- **Tier 1 — the core record.** Twelve fields, completed for every activity without exception, target completion time under five minutes. It captures what happened, who convened it, roughly who was there, what was produced, and where the outputs are deposited. It is designed to be completed on a phone in the room afterwards.
- **Tier 2 — the deep look.** A fuller inquiry applied to three or four activities per year, including follow-up contact with participants and, where relevant, partner interviews. Critically, the selection criterion is **learning value, not size** — the organisation should look hardest at the activity it understands least, which will often be a small or a failed one.

The instinct in most organisations is to apply the deep look to the flagship programme, because that is what the funder asks about. That instinct should be resisted: the flagship is the activity about which the organisation already has the most tacit knowledge, so the marginal information gain is lowest.

6.2 Handling outcomes that resist measurement

Three of KED's intended outcomes — local capacity, cultural continuity, and heritage entering decision-making — are of the kind routinely declared "unmeasurable" and then quietly dropped. The proposed treatment differs by outcome, because the reason each is difficult differs.

Outcome	Why it resists measurement	Proposed treatment	What is deliberately not done
Local capacity to document and claim heritage	Capacity is a disposition, not an event; training completion is a poor proxy	Independence check at six months: did the group produce a documentation output without KED co-authorship, hold the files itself, and speak for itself publicly? Scored on a three-point rubric with a supporting quotation recorded	Number of people trained is retained as an output only and is never reported as capacity
Cultural continuity	The timescale exceeds any project; direct measurement is not credible	A three-signal panel read together annually — practice recurring without external funding; participation by an age cohort previously absent; re-use of KED material by others. Read in a 90-minute team session; the judgement and its reasoning are recorded	No composite score. Combining these into a single index would fabricate precision that does not exist

Outcome	Why it resists measurement	Proposed treatment	What is deliberately not done
Heritage in decision-making	Many actors contribute; attribution is not available	A contribution register with a four-step uptake ladder: acknowledged → cited → incorporated → decision changed. Each entry names the other actors involved	No claim of attribution. The register is explicitly a record of contribution, and reviewers are told so

The third column is where the technical work sits; the fourth is where the credibility sits. In my experience the fastest way for a small organisation to lose a funder's trust is to over-claim on precisely these outcomes, and the fastest way to build it is to show the measurement decisions that were declined and why. A worked indicator reference sheet is at Annex A.

6.3 Making existing qualitative material do work

Before commissioning new instruments, Phase 2 will code the existing corpus of event reports and interview material against the outcome framework. This is a matter of sequence, and it is not merely economical. Retrospective coding of material collected for other purposes is a partial check on the framework itself: if an outcome domain has no trace in seven years of the organisation's own records, that is evidence either that the outcome is not actually being pursued or that the framework has been written from the grant applications rather than from the work. Both are worth knowing before tools are built.

This work is conditional on the consent and data-protection protocol identified at 4.6 being in place first. Where the existing consent basis cannot support analysis, the material stays in the archive and is not used.

6.4 Data management proportionate to a five-person staff team

A dedicated M&E platform was considered and rejected. Licence cost was a factor; administration was the decisive one. A platform requires a named owner with time protected for it, and KED's five paid staff each carry programme delivery across chapters, none with a MEL mandate. Within eighteen months an unowned platform becomes a second place where data is not entered. The recommendation is a structured form feeding a single register, with the archive holding the evidence and a short annual learning file holding the judgements.

Component	Function	Design constraint it satisfies
Core record form (12 fields)	Captures Tier 1 data at the point of activity, offline-capable	Under five minutes; no login required; works on a phone
Single activity register	One row per activity across all chapters; the only source used for reporting	One named owner per chapter; no aggregation step at report time
Evidence archive	Single custodial location for photographs, surveys, recordings, with a deposit step at activity closure	Directly addresses finding 4.4; access-controlled for sensitive material
Annual learning file	Short written record of the judgements made against the continuity panel and the contribution register, with reasoning	Makes qualitative judgement auditable without converting it into false numbers

A sunset rule is proposed alongside the system: any indicator not used in a documented decision or an external report within twelve months is removed. Small organisations accumulate indicators the way they accumulate mailing lists, and the accumulated weight is what eventually causes the system to be abandoned.

The rule is a maintenance mechanism, and it should be minuted by the board so that removal does not require anyone to argue for it.

6.5 Donor reporting

The proposal is to change the reporting process rather than the reporting formats. Requirements from KED's six current and recent funders were mapped into a single superset; the register is designed so that each funder's report is a filter applied to it rather than a reconstruction from scratch. On the assessment's estimates this reduces preparation from three to four person-days to well under one, and — more importantly — makes the same figure appear the same way in every document.

The expansion after 2023 sharpens this. Emergency and post-disaster funding arrives with shorter reporting cycles and tighter verification expectations than the grants KED was used to, and the reconstruction method described at 4.5 does not survive contact with them. The register is therefore not an efficiency measure alone; it is the condition of KED remaining eligible for the kind of funding its newest programme depends on.

7. Feasibility, sequencing and risk

The system described above is smaller than the one KED currently has on paper. That is intentional, and it is the main thing the assessment is asking the board to accept.

Risk	Why it is credible here	Mitigation built into the design
Volunteer turnover erases the system	Two of the four people who built previous tools have left; institutional memory sits in individuals	Twelve fields, no software to learn, written owner per chapter, and a deposit step tied to activity closure rather than to a person
Chapters experience monitoring as central control	Chapter autonomy is constitutive of KED's identity, and was raised in the workshop by three of five chapters	Chapters own and can see their own data; the annual learning session is peer-facilitated, not audit-framed; aggregation is transparent
The two newest chapters are asked to carry the most	Adana and Mersin hold the heritage caseload but have existed since 2023 and have the thinnest routines	Tier 1 form piloted in Adana first, and the twelve fields set at what a new chapter can sustain rather than at what an established one could
The framework becomes an aspiration document	The 2021 strategy note met this fate	Tier 1 form piloted in week two of Phase 2, before the results framework is finalised, so the framework is constrained by what the form can actually carry
Over-collection returns	Each new funder adds requests and nothing is ever removed	Twelve-month sunset rule, minuted by the board
Sensitive material is mishandled	Testimony from displaced households is already held without adequate consent basis	Consent and data-protection protocol precedes any analysis of existing qualitative material; access controls on the archive

8. Reflection on the assessment process

Two aspects of Phase 1 would be done differently, and are recorded here because the same errors are easy to repeat.

The results framework was drafted too early. Roughly a week was spent on a draft outcome structure before the data audit was complete. When the audit revealed the custody problem at 4.4, the draft had to be substantially revised, because a framework that assumes evidence is retrievable is a different framework from one that does not. In a small-organisation assessment, the data and tools audit should precede framework drafting, not run alongside it. The general lesson: establish what evidence the organisation can actually lay hands on before deciding what it should measure.

The consent question should have been raised in week one. It surfaced in week three, at which point the assessment had already planned participant follow-up that could not ethically proceed. This cost a planned strand of primary data. In any assignment involving an organisation that holds testimony from vulnerable groups — and after February 2023, KED holds a great deal of it — the consent basis is an inception-stage question, not a findings-stage one, and it belongs in the inception note as a go/no-go condition.

One judgement is worth defending rather than revising. The custody fix at 4.4 was implemented immediately rather than deferred to Phase 2, which departed from the agreed workplan. Sequencing discipline matters in a six-month assignment, but material that is actively being lost is not a Phase 2 problem, and the fix was cheap enough that the disruption was justified. The board was informed in writing and the workplan revised, rather than the deviation absorbed silently.

Annex A — Indicator reference sheet (extract, 2 of 11)

Each indicator in the proposed set carries a reference sheet of this form. The final two rows are the ones most often omitted, and are the reason the sheets exist: an indicator without a named use decays into a reporting obligation, and an indicator without stated limitations invites over-claiming.

A.1 — Independent documentation by supported local groups

Field	Entry
Outcome served	Local groups have the capacity to document and make claims on heritage under threat
Indicator	Number of supported local groups producing at least one documentation output within six months of KED support, without KED co-authorship
Type / level	Quantitative; outcome level; annual
Data source	Output register; six-month follow-up call (three scripted questions)
Collection responsibility	Chapter focal point; logged centrally by coordination
Disaggregation	By chapter; by whether the group existed before KED contact
Companion qualitative question	"Who decided what to document, and who was asked to speak about it publicly?" — verbatim response recorded against a three-point independence rubric
Decision this feeds	Annual allocation between direct documentation by KED and support to local groups — the trade-off identified at 4.1
Known limitations	Attribution is weak: groups may have acted without KED. Treated as a contribution signal only. Six months is short for this outcome and the threshold is provisional pending two cycles of data

A.2 — Uptake of KED evidence in formal decision processes

Field	Entry
Outcome served	Heritage considerations enter formal urban decision-making
Indicator	Documented instances in which KED-produced evidence or position is acknowledged, cited, incorporated, or associated with a changed decision by a public authority, conservation board, court, professional chamber or major media outlet
Type / level	Quantitative count on a four-step ladder, with a mandatory narrative entry per instance; outcome level; continuous logging, annual review
Data source	Contribution register, maintained by chapters as instances occur; verified against the public record
Collection responsibility	Chapter focal point at the time of the instance — not reconstructed at reporting time
Disaggregation	By ladder step; by decision forum; by site
Companion qualitative question	"Which other actors contributed to this outcome, and what would plausibly have happened without KED's input?" — recorded in the register entry
Decision this feeds	Whether to sustain, expand or withdraw from a given advocacy engagement; board-level prioritisation between chapters
Known limitations	Records contribution, never attribution, and is presented to funders as such. Higher ladder steps are rare and the count will be low; it should not be read as a performance trend year to year. Susceptible to under-recording when volunteers are stretched, which is itself worth monitoring

End of extract. The workplan and budget section and Annexes B–I are omitted from this sample.